Uppsala University

Master's Thesis

Thesis Proposal

Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate

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1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Brief Overview

Through this thesis project, I apply transformative game design theory and best practices to create a new competitive debating format. This research employs Research through Design (RtD) methodology to develop and playtest an alternative debate format that addresses systematic problems in widely-used formats, particularly World Schools and British Parliamentary debate.

1.2 Motivation

I approach this research as a complete community member with 15 years of experience in competitive debate across multiple roles: debater, judge, coach, and organizer. This insider perspective informs my reformist motivation to improve formats that have both shaped and limited the community I value. I believe debate is a class of role-playing games with immense transformative potential, yet the design of major formats remains calcified, with game design theories and practices entirely absent from attempts to improve them.

1.3 Problem Statement

Based on my fifteen years of observation, participation, and informal conversations with fellow practitioners, I hypothesize that the two most popular debate formats, World Schools and British Parliamentary, whose communities in Europe are deeply intertwined, exhibit the following problematic tendencies:

First, they seem to push debaters towards value convergence, potentially causing them to become less tolerant of people with different values and diminishing their ability to convince people from different backgrounds. Second, they appear to teach debaters to speak very fast and with extreme information density, which could diminish their ability to meaningfully support their positions to people not trained as debate judges. Third, in my opinion they push communities towards competitive hierarchical behavior that undermines psychological safety.

These observations, while grounded in extensive practitioner experience, have not been systematically validated through empirical research and this thesis does not intend to extensively prove them, although a later section will present their echoes in literature. However, it does try to frame my process of designing a format that addresses these hypothesized problems, and through that design process, to generate evidence about how these problems are triggered by and are solvable through the design of the game.

1.4 Research Question

How can the application of transformative game design theory inform the creation of a competitive debate format that is a better transformative container?

1.5 Scope and Limitations

This thesis aims to demonstrate proof of concept: that alternative debate formats can be systematically designed to address problems, and that such designs produce observable and articulable differences in participant experience. In particular it will try to demonstrate how a debate format can address one or more of the identified problems without sacrificing entertainment value, competitive appeal or educational potential.

The thesis does not aim to produce robust claims about long-term educational efficacy or entertainment value, as such claims would require longitudinal studies with larger samples than a master's thesis permits. Its main contribution to knowledge is the simple proof that debate formats can be designed better if looked at as roleplaying games. That is why the research will involve only approximately 10 playtest sessions over two months with experienced debaters from the Romanian debate community, culminating in qualitative analysis of observational and interview data that should be sufficient to prove how the methodology of design employed by this study can be systematically used to improve the debate landscape.

2 BACKGROUND AND LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Topic Overview

2.2 Debate as Transformative Game

Academic debate formats are games. Following Salen and Zimmerman (2004), a game is a system in which players engage in artificial conflict, defined by rules, resulting in a quantifiable outcome. Academic debate satisfies all criteria: rules, participants, winners, losers, tournaments, and scoring systems. Alfred Snider's 1982 doctoral dissertation at the University of Kansas, along with his subsequent publication (Snider, 1984), established the scholarly foundation for viewing debate as a game while documenting its educational benefits.

Empirical studies confirm debate's significant transformative effects. Mezuk (2009) found Chicago Debate League participants 70% more likely to graduate and three times less likely to drop out. Allen et al. (1999) found significant positive effects of forensics education on critical thinking across multiple studies. Bellon (2000) synthesized research from competitive forensics, communication pedagogy, and educational psychology to provide comprehensive justification for debate across the curriculum.

Within forensics pedagogy, substantial research documents debate's multifaceted educational benefits through field-specific theoretical frameworks. Critical thinking development operates through "intellectual disequilibrium," where the interactive debating process forces students to rework their mental structures (Colbert, 1995/2002), operationalized through problem definition via "topicality" and information selection through "burden of proof" (Colbert, 1995/2002; Hill, 1993/2002). Debaters must analyze authoritative proof to recognize stated and unstated assumptions while judging the validity of causal inferences (Colbert, 1995/2002). Beyond cognitive gains, debate serves as a vehicle for empowerment, particularly for previously "silenced student populations" who develop their own voice through the activity (Snider, 2003), with Urban Debate Leagues using the debate process to provide empowerment in academically challenged environments (Snider, 2003). The activity cultivates

a "democratic ethos" including the ability to justify convictions in public, respect minority views, and evaluate opposing arguments critically (Hicks, 1998/2002a). Oral communication proficiency develops through audience adaptation mechanisms, where students must analyze listeners' beliefs and norms to frame compelling narratives (Cirlin, 1997/2002), while parliamentary formats foster extemporaneous thinking and speaking abilities (Whitmore, 1998/2002). Debate functions as a "laboratory" for intensive research and information management (Broda-Bahm, 2002), with the intensity of preparation for high-level policy debate frequently compared to master's thesis work (Combs, 2002a). Finally, debate provides a socialization mechanism, integrating students into a sub-culture with its own rules, "map" of reality, and "sermonic" language that shapes how they perceive and influence the world (Cirlin, 1997/2002), with specialized language enhancing students' sense of belonging to an intellectual community (Kargacin, 1998/2002).

Although the merits of debate have been academically documented, I have yet to find any paper that analyzes major formats from a game design perspective or presents academic debating as a role-playing game, though Bowman's 2014 literature review (Bowman, 2014) acknowledges related pedagogical approaches such as process drama and simulation as role-playing games.

Addressing this gap in literature, applying game design lenses and expertise to the analysis and improvement of debate formats, is the main contribution to knowledge that I seek to start making through this paper.

2.3 Debate as Role-Playing Game

In the World Schools format, the one I will most focus on in this paper, in every debate there are two teams which receive a motion (e.g., "This House Would legalize the possession of drugs"). Teams are randomly assigned to opposite sides: Proposition/Government or Opposition. They deliver alternating speeches as if they were individuals supporting or opposing the motion. Judges listen as someone with no opinion on the motion, expert in debate rules, and averagely informed, deciding who most convinced the character they role-play. The debate ends with the judge ruling who won, explaining their decision and then offering feedback for improvement to the teams.

Understanding debate's relationship to role-playing games requires first establishing what role-playing games are and where debate fits among related practices. As Zagal and Deterding (2024) observe, defining role-playing games is notoriously contentious, with scholars, designers, and practitioners disagreeing across forms, styles, and communities. However, certain characteristics commonly recur: role-playing games are play activities revolving around the rule-structured creation and enactment of characters in a fictional world, where players define and pursue their own goals with considerable choice in what actions they can attempt (Zagal & Deterding, 2024). Bowman et al. (2025) offer a functional definition: analog role-playing games are "co-creative experiences in which participants immerse into fictional characters and realities for a bounded period of time and improvise through spontaneous, emergent playfulness" (p. 16).

Transformative game design literature explicitly positions debate among "cousin forms" of analog role-playing games (Bowman, 2014; Bowman et al., 2025), alongside simulations, educational role-playing, improv theatre, and psychodrama. The distinction rests not on the

act of role-playing itself, which is much the same regardless of community, but on practices, norms, and innovations developing within each community. For the analytical purpose of usefully employing the body of theory developed to explain how and how better can role-playing games harness positive transformative energies, this is already enough to justify the following section. As will be later revealed, most of the theory developed in what I call the "Nordic School" of roleplaying game design explains processes common to all role-playing activities. Going even further however, competitive debate occupies an unusual position among these cousin forms, one that warrants closer examination. While debate is indeed used in educational contexts, it differs fundamentally from close cousins such as work simulations or classroom exercises in ways that bring it closer to analog role-playing games proper. Three theoretical dimensions illuminate this proximity: the depth of character immersion, the strength of alibi, and the leisure-community dimension.

First, regarding immersion: As opposed to work simulations or boardgames, debate requires players togenuinely inhabit an epistemic stance, constructing and defending arguments as if they believed them. This process of active perspective-taking requires what Bowman (2010) calls developing a "theory of mind" outside one's own. The debater must anticipate objections, identify weaknesses, and respond to challenges as someone who holds the assigned position, a cognitive demand that approaches the immersion into character central to role-playing games. I myself felt and many colleague debaters also expressed how the extreme cognitive load that performance in debate demands is incompatible with not fully assuming for the duration of the debate the opinion demanded by the motion, only to then discard it easily in time for the next debate (especially in a competition).

Bowman (2010) identifies nine types of relationships between players and characters, including the "Fragmented Self," where a facet of the player's personality or interests becomes magnified into a central character trait. Debate characters fit this framework: they represent fragmented selves whose defining feature is epistemic commitment to a particular position. The debater role-plays as someone who believes the motion should pass or fail, adopting that argumentative perspective as the character's core identity. They find in themselves beliefs they can hold that support the position and banish from thought all other, focusing on a fragment of their identity.

Second, regarding alibi: this concept describes how game participants can act with lessened social consequences, encouraging risk-taking and willingness to fail (Deterding, 2017). Debate provides robust alibi through its competitive frame. Because debate is "just a game," debaters can advance positions they might not advocate publicly, explore uncomfortable arguments, and fail without lasting consequences to reputation. Work simulations do not offer that. This enables the identity experimentation that Bowman et al. (2025) identify as central to transformational containers.

Third, regarding the leisure-community dimension: competitive debate possesses passionate discourse communities distinguishing role-playing games from cousin forms. The World Schools and British Parliamentary circuits encompass hundreds of competitions. Debaters participate voluntarily, often for decades; they develop specialized terminology, shared references, and community norms; they attend tournaments analogous to gaming conventions. The activity is often pursued for its intrinsic satisfactions, not merely as preparation for external goal. This leisure dimension, combined with the vibrant discourse community, positions competitive debate closer to role-playing games than to the educational simulations

with which it shares surface similarities.

Furthermore, evidence for debate's role-playing dimension appears throughout its practice. Experienced coaches regularly employ explicit role-playing techniques during preparation, asking debaters to "become" stakeholders affected by policies. As Snider (1999) emphasizes, the better debater "portrays an image of an intelligent person who is seeking to understand and discover the truth," a fundamentally performative stance requiring adoption of a character oriented toward inquiry rather than mere victory. Furthermore, debate ethos as I witnessed it is summoned through traditions that explicitly stage parliamentary fiction: bench-pounding, heckling, Points of Information delivered as if holding onto wigs. The format performs a fiction of parliamentary deliberation, with debaters and judges alike participating in theatrical conventions inherited from eighteenth-century British debate culture.

Genuine differences between debate and games that are more traditionally seen as analogue role-playing games, such as Dungeons and Dragons, are undeniable: debate lacks the narrative worldbuilding, the character backstories, and the extended campaign structures of tabletop or live-action role-playing. But it is important to recognize that debate's role-playing operates through the same psychological mechanisms and this justifies applying the substantial body of transformative game design scholarship to understand how debate produces its educational effects and, more importantly, how design choices might enhance or undermine those effects.

2.4 Literature Review of Format Critiques

The usefulness of applying transformative game design theory to attempt solving the problems of current debate formats comes also from the apparent failure of current scholarly works in the same endeavor. The largest body of work that analyzes debate as an educational tool is that of forensics pedagogy. This centers around the more predominant formats played in the US (especially American Policy). I will thus focus on reviewing what literature was written that echoes the problems I set out to solve and that forms arguments that are also applicable to the formats that I seek to improve (especially the World Schools format).

2.4.1 The Technical-Public Sphere Tension

A fundamental critique pervading the literature concerns the evolution of debate formats away from public sphere accessibility toward technical sphere insularity. Combs (2002b) documents how both NDT (National Debate Tournament) and CEDA (Cross Examination Debate Association) have evolved into technical sphere activities characterized by: expert-level topic knowledge, speaking rates exceeding what most listeners can process, sophisticated analytical models inaccessible to non-specialists, heavy reliance on extensive note-taking, and specially trained judges.

This has effect both on my critique on value converge as well as related to public speaking abilities.

2.4.2 Value Convergence and Ideological Homogenization

A significant concern in the literature relates to what I coined above as value convergence. McGee (2002) observes that debaters increasingly adopt what he terms "emancipatory rhetoric", advocacy for radical social change grounded in critical theory, feminism, or other transformative frameworks. While such advocacy is intellectually legitimate, the discursive practices of debate communities may create pressure toward ideological conformity.

The "closed system" dynamic described by Harris and Smith, cited in Combs (2002b), creates conditions conducive to value convergence. In academic debate, tournament practices are insulated from external feedback and where judges who deviate from community norms are "effectively excluded from the system much like the human system rejects certain bacteria" (Combs, 2002b, p. 40). This dynamic may cultivate shared assumptions that, while facilitating intra-community communication, potentially diminish debaters' capacity to engage persuasively with those holding different values.

Crenshaw's work on feminism in debate, cited by McGee (2002), illustrates how "argument borrowing" can lead to reductionist treatment of complex intellectual traditions. When debaters adopt arguments primarily for strategic advantage rather than genuine engagement with underlying ideas, the result may be superficial understanding and reduced capacity for authentic cross-ideological dialogue.

2.4.3 Delivery Practices and Communicative Capacity

Colbert, cited in Combs (2002b), found that average CEDA debaters spoke at approximately 237 words per minute, while NDT finalists averaged 284 words per minute, with some exceeding 300 words per minute—rates that "greatly exceed what is considered optimal for normal speaking" (Combs, 2002b, p. 36).

While World Schools and British Parliamentary formats explicitly discourage talking fast through style-based evaluation, similar pressures toward information density exist, and the skills developed may not transfer to contexts without expert judges. The difficulty to solve this is also captured in literature. (Hicks, 2002b) treats the difficulty of defining for what type of audience should debaters make themselves persuasive, comparing Weiss (2002)'s "audience standard" (being understandable to a regular audience) to his "ideal of public reason" (being understandable to the perfect rational listener), presenting how some educational value is lost either way.

2.4.4 Hierarchical Dynamics and Psychological Safety

In this issue I have observed forensics pedagogy literature is thinnest. Although Snider approaches the topics of safety and ethics both in his Code of the Debate (Snider, 1999), the failures of such practices are not documented. The hermetic nature of debate communities, which might point towards the importance of social status within them (which intuitively in a competitive sport is bred also through winning) is supported through some claims. Riley and Hollihan for example suggest that approximately three years of debate experience are required to compete effectively on the national circuit, effectively excluding students without extensive high school preparation (Combs, 2002b, p. 38).

2.5 Gap Identification

This literature review reveals a significant gap. Forensics pedagogy has established debate's educational benefits and identified tensions, but has not systematically applied game design frameworks to analyze how specific format mechanics produce specific effects. Transformative role-playing game theory provides sophisticated tools for understanding how structured play produces personal change, but has not been applied to competitive debate. Addressing this gap is the central contribution of this thesis.

3 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This section develops an integrated framework synthesizing transformative role-playing game theory, learning theory, and procedural rhetoric to explain debate's transformative mechanisms and guide design decisions.

3.1 Core Theoretical Constructs

3.1.1 The Transformational Container

The transformational container, adapted to role-playing games by Bowman and Hugaas (2021) from psychoanalytic theory (Winnicott, 1960), is a bounded space providing sufficient safety for participants to take risks and experiment with new ways of being, connecting to Huizinga (1958) concept of the "magic circle." Debate creates such a container through explicit rules establishing boundaries, a competitive frame that paradoxically enables safety through alibi (Deterding, 2017) (because debate is "just a game"), and the judge as containing authority. However, the container's effectiveness depends on design: if competitive pressures become overwhelming or hierarchies become rigid, transformational potential is compromised.

3.1.2 Bleed as Transformative Mechanism

Following Hugaas (2024), bleed describes the bidirectional spillover of psychological contents between player and character (or in debate, between the debater and their assigned position). This concept is crucial for understanding how debate produces its educational effects.

Memetic bleed, the transfer of ideas and perspectives, explains how debaters develop epistemic humility. First of all through the very direct memetic bleed of the opinions of the role played in a debate towards the debater, arguments which can be summoned again outside of the debate. But more than that, after years of arguing for positions contrary to their beliefs, debaters bleed into accepting that reasonable people can formulate opposing views, that anything can be argued convincingly, and that argumentative power does not equate with being right.

This bleed of a certain humble attitude connects to Bogost (2007) concept of procedural rhetoric. Bogost argues that every game, though its systems and rules, reflects a certain world-view, that players in time may be persuaded of. The rules of debate inherently postulate that anyone can support anything and that through dialectic processes of presenting

arguments for and against, not truth is reached, but a showcase of who is more capable in argument (as two opposite decisions could be taken in two different rounds on the same motion). Thus experienced debaters ideally learn to acknowledge how there may be much truth in the points made also by the less skilled in argument.

Procedural bleed, the transfer of physical abilities and habits, explains skill development. The rhetorical habits, speaking patterns, and argumentative reflexes developed through competition bleed into debaters' ordinary communication, producing the documented improvements in public speaking and critical thinking.

Emancipatory bleed (Kemper, 2017, 2020) explains debate's particular power for students from marginalized backgrounds. For students where eloquent public speaking was not modeled, debate provides a transformational container to discover and develop their voice. Being taken seriously as intellectuals, having ideas weighed on merits rather than dismissed based on identity, produces lasting changes in self-concept and capability.

3.1.3 Zone of Proximal Development and Scaffolded Learning

Vygotsky (1978) zone of proximal development explains how debate creates naturally occurring scaffolding: power-pairing ensures challenges remain within the zone where growth occurs, while judges provide guided instruction through post-debate feedback. The debate cycle naturally embodies Kolb (1984) experiential learning model, with the debrief—which Crookall (2014) and Daniau (2016) identify as essential to transformation—built into debate through the oral critique.

3.2 Reframing Forensics Pedagogy Critiques through Transformative Game Design

The critiques identified within forensics pedagogy, echoing the issues identified during the problem statement, can be productively reframed through the theoretical mechanisms of transformative game design, illuminating not only why these problems occur but also suggesting design-based interventions.

3.2.1 Value Convergence as Corrupted Memetic Bleed

TWhat I coined as value convergence can be seen as a failure in memetic bleed. The intended transformative outcome of debate is epistemic humility. However, memetic bleed is mediated by judges, creating vulnerability to what I term *evaluative bleed-in*. Judges role-play as neutral arbiters, but this role is cognitively demanding and vaguely specified. When judges share common backgrounds, their collective bleed-in produces systematic biases.

Following Bowman et al. (2025), the container's effectiveness requires psychological safety for all participants, including judges. When judges face social consequences for heterodox that deviate from "emancipatory rhetoric" community consensus, the alibi protecting experimental judgment erodes. What bleeds into debaters is the community's strategic equilibrium rather than appreciation for intellectual diversity. Debaters, optimizing for competitive success, do "argument borrowing", adapting strategically: arguments that succeed in elimi-

nation rounds or from high-status debaters become templates, and approaches aligned with perceived judicial values propagate.

Design interventions might therefore diversify audiences debaters must persuade, strengthen judge alibi through structural features, and explicitly distinguish in debriefing between "what wins debates" and "what constitutes good reasoning."

3.2.2 Information Density and Misaligned Procedural Bleed

The critique of information-dense speaking represents misalignment in procedural bleed. When formats reward rapid delivery optimized for expert judges, debaters develop procedural habits adapted to highly specific audiences. The skills that bleed out are real but narrowly optimized, representing failure of transfer.

Design interventions might include evaluation criteria rewarding accessibility alongside substance, or judging paradigms simulating general audiences. By constructing vivid characters for judges to role-play, the bleed-in from character to judge can itself become memetic, the judge taking on the character's understanding while maintaining expert-level rule comprehension.

3.2.3 Competitive Pressure and the Compromised Container

When competitive pressures become overwhelming, when tournament success determines status and self-worth, the alibi enabling transformation erodes. Participants can no longer treat debate as "just a game" because stakes have become too real.

This compromise cascades through other mechanisms. Emancipatory bleed requires a container where being taken seriously is possible; rigid hierarchies block this for those positioned as subordinate. The zone of proximal development requires calibrated challenges; competitive anxiety may prevent productive struggle or reflective observation.

Design interventions might distribute status more broadly, emphasize growth over victory, strengthen alibi by making explicit the distinction between game performance and personal worth, and incorporate safety practices adapted from larp design (Bowman et al., 2025).

3.2.4 Implications for Design

This reframing generates specific predictions. Formats designed to maximize transformation should: (1) structure memetic bleed toward epistemic humility through debriefing practices connecting argumentative experiences to personal development; (2) align procedural bleed with transferable communication skills by strengthening judge alibi to role-play as specific general audience members; and (3) maintain container safety by preventing competitive success from conflating with personal worth.

4 METHODS

4.1 Design Philosophy

This research employs Research through Design (RtD) as primary methodological framework. RtD positions the design process itself as inquiry, where knowledge emerges through making and iterating upon designed artifacts (Coulton & Hook, 2017; J. Zimmerman et al., 2007). The design process follows E. Zimmerman (2003) iterative methodology, treating play as research. Each playtest generates data informing subsequent decisions, creating a spiral of refined understanding.

4.2 Development Process

Development unfolds through three cyclical phases. In the generation phase, I explore potential mechanics addressing theoretically-identified problems, using brainstorming sessions, design conversations with debate peers, and analysis of existing formats. In the critical scrutiny phase, I evaluate whether candidate designs congruently address problems without introducing new difficulties (e.g., judge cognitive load, time limitations), using the theoretical framework as evaluation criteria. In the validation phase, surviving elements undergo increasingly rigorous testing: informal design conversations with experienced debaters, small pilot playtests identifying mechanical problems, and a larger playtest as a mini-competition with structured observation and interview protocols.

These phases spiral until the format demonstrates sufficient coherence, playability, and alignment with transformational goals, or allocated resources run out. I intend to run two small playtests of one debate each, then a larger playtest as a small full-day competition.

4.3 Research Methods

For analyzing the quality of the design I will organize playtests. During these playtests the research methods used will be observation and semi-structured interviews, followed by a qualitative data analysis.

4.3.1 Participant Observation

Following Baker (2006), I will adopt a participant-as-observer role during playtests. My researcher status will be known, but I will participate actively in some debates to obtain firsthand understanding. When observing debates where not participating, I will function as observer-as-participant: present and known but not actively engaged.

Observation will focus on overall debate flow and more granularly on behaviors relevant to entertainment value, rule legibility and adherence ease, and elements distinct from standard formats, judging whether these indicate positive or negative tendencies vis-à-vis identified problems and the theoretical framework's predictions.

Informed by the advice of Spradley (1980), I will record field notes in two phases: condensed and expanded. Condensed notes, taken during debates, will capture key moments,

quotations, and behavioral observations using structured protocols. Expanded notes, written within 24 hours of the playtests, will elaborate, add contextual observations, and record analytical reflections. All debates will be audio/video-recorded with consent to enable field note verification and capture verbal content not fully documented in real-time.

Anticipated observation includes approximately 10 structured playtest sessions over two months: two sessions with 1–2 individual debates and one larger session with remaining debates.

4.3.2 Participants

I will recruit debaters for playtests with the aid of ARDOR Muntenia, the NGO managing the debate community in Bucharest and the south of Romania. They will both directly inquire various clubs if they are interested in including a playtest as part of their weekly activity and will issue open calls for debaters in organizing the playtests, especially the small competition.

In Romania, the young adults (not minors) debate community is quite homogenous regarding debate experience, as almost all are senior debaters with training experience. Many of these are students or professionals living in Bucharest. The sample answering my open call will likely be representative in debate experience for the most probable target outside this research: experienced, not novice, debaters.

The majority of Romanian debaters are minors. Ideally, the study would involve minor participants, but ethical guidelines pushed toward this strategy as best alternative.

The target sample comprises approximately 30–40 participants across all playtest sessions, with 12–15 participating in semi-structured interviews. This sample size is justified by the proof-of-concept nature of the research: the goal is demonstrating that design-based interventions can produce articulable differences in experience, not establishing generalizable population-level effects.

4.3.3 Semi-Structured Interviews

Interviews complement observation by accessing perspectives not directly observable. Interview participants will be recruited through purposive sampling from playtest participants, capturing diverse perspectives: both debaters and judges (offering distinct perspectives); winners and losers (as performance may affect format perception); and different educational backgrounds (primarily teachers/trainers versus debaters).

Following Knott et al. (2022), the target is 12–15 interviews, sufficient for theoretical saturation while remaining feasible.

Interviews will center on game feedback, following a topic guide developed based on the particular design reached and iterated upon. Topics will cover general experience (positive/negative, contrast with other formats, difficulty), intentions to play in this format or use elements of it, and issues related to transformative goals as identified through the theoretical framework.

Interviews will occur within one week of participation ensuring fresh recall, ideally immediately after debates. Duration will be approximately 15–20 minutes, conducted in person or via video call depending on preference, and transcribed for analysis.

4.4 Data Analysis

Analysis follows a design-oriented comparative approach. The primary purpose is not generating generalizable theory but informing ongoing design decisions and articulating how the designed format produces different experiences than existing formats. This aligns with experimental game design methodology (Waern & Back, 2015), where design experimentation becomes research when "the aim is to understand something generic, some more fundamental aspect of game design."

Between playtest sessions, rapid analysis will focus on actionable insights: what mechanics worked and should be preserved, what did not work and caused confusion or disengagement, and what surprised me and suggests new opportunities. This treats playtesting as "play as research" (E. Zimmerman, 2003), with each session generating questions informing the next design cycle.

After the final playtest, systematic comparative analysis will proceed through three phases. First, initial coding following Lankoski and Björk (2015) will identify and label data segments describing participant experiences, behaviors, and reflections with descriptive rather than interpretive codes. Second, comparative code analysis will organize codes into categories structured around theoretical constructs, coding for continuity (experiences similar to traditional formats), difference (experiences diverging), and novelty (experiences unique to the designed format). Third, articulation of design principles will connect observed effects to specific format mechanics, examining relationships between game components, player actions, and goals.

This approach can demonstrate: (a) the designed format produces experiences participants describe as different; (b) specific mechanics appear connected to specific differences; and (c) differences align with intended goals. It cannot demonstrate persistence, superiority, or generalizability, appropriate limitations for proof-of-concept Research through Design where contribution lies in demonstrating that systematic design can address identified problems and in articulating design principles meriting further investigation or usage.

4.5 Ethical Considerations

This research adheres to Uppsala University's ethical guidelines for research involving human participants. All playtest participants will be informed of the purpose and context, how data will be gathered, stored, and analyzed, both during and after recruitment. All will be able to offer and retract consent, granularly or wholesale, to participation in every process part and to data being collected, stored, or used. Peers whose input I use in developing this format will be informed of context and credited. All data will be stored securely in encrypted Microsoft OneDrive offered by Uppsala University, separated by content type, and deleted once thesis development and presentation is complete. All data will be anonymized and not publicly available.

To ensure psychological safety, the rigorous ethical standards imposed by the ARDOR Ethical Guide and ARDOR Trainer Safety Guide will be followed. Debate topics will avoid personal trauma topics and debaters will be able to refuse to engage with motions. Debaters will be able to always talk to a third-party equity officer regarding emotional safety issues and report abusive or distressing behavior. During debates, all debaters will be able to exit

without explanation.

Beyond these, all participants will have pre-session briefing and post-session debrief providing chances to address potential distressing elements before activity and discuss experience afterwards.

4.6 Positionality and Reflexivity

I approach this research as a complete community member (Adler & Adler, 1987). My fifteen years in competitive debate have shaped not only my knowledge but my values, assumptions, and emotional investments. This informs several positions I must acknowledge: insider knowledge enabling nuanced understanding but potentially creating blind spots; reformist motivation emerging from genuine frustration with existing formats, predisposing me toward confirming my critique; a novel disciplinary lens through game design rather than the educational or rhetorical frameworks common in forensics scholarship; and power dynamics created by my status as former Team Romania coach and successful debater, which may influence participant responses. My competitive success within the formats I critique creates additional tension regarding whether my familiarity enables recognition of subtle issues or obscures problems I cannot fully perceive.

To support reflexive awareness, I will maintain a reflexive journal and follow each interview with a reflexive note (Knott et al., 2022), actively seeking data contradicting expectations. Given that some participants will be known to me, recruitment will be externalized to ARDOR Muntenia staff, and I will flag data from participants with close prior relationships while triangulating self-report data with observational data where possible.

5 Conclusion

Alfred "Tuna" Snider was first to recognize debate as a game and to apply play logic to its analysis, doing this way before game design was a recognized discipline. Through his career as a teacher and scholar he championed the transformative power of playing this game with joy, passion and determination. Although many of his students, one of whom I was very privileged to be, did continue his work in fields such as civics, education, rhetoric and his own specialty of forensics, none used game-design know-how to answer the question that most naturally flows from his argument that debate is a game: how can we make it a better game?

This thesis seeks to begin answering that question. By applying transformative game design theory to competitive debate, it aims to demonstrate that systematic design interventions can address identified problems while preserving debate's documented benefits. The contribution lies not in producing a finished format but in establishing proof of concept: that the intersection of game design scholarship and forensics pedagogy offers productive tools for format improvement, and in articulating design principles worthy of further development and investigation.

Timeline Annex

- **01–15 January:** Thesis proposal refining
- **16–31 January:** Design of the new format, conversations with fellow senior debaters and with other game designers; organizing the first playtest
- **01–15 February:** First pilot playtest, first interviews, announcing the mini-competition and opening registration, iteration on the game design
- **16–28 February:** Second pilot playtest and interviews, finishing registrations for the mini-competition, iteration on the game design
- **01–20 March:** Mini-competition extensive playtests, running all remaining interviews
- **21 March–01 May:** Data analysis, further theoretical inquiries, thesis writing

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